



Introduction to the Bible

Your guide to understanding the Bible and reading it every day

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Introduction

You may be holding a copy of the Bible in your hands for the very first time, or you may have been hearing about it since childhood at church without ever daring to open it and read it yourself. It may seem huge and complicated to you, full of strange names and events far removed from your daily life. This little book was written for you in particular. It is a simple companion that takes your hand step by step, to turn that feeling of awe or confusion into real joy in God's Word.

In the pages that follow you will find clear answers to the questions every beginner asks: What is the Bible? How was it written? What is inside it? How did it reach us in this form? Who is Jesus Christ in its pages? Then we move from knowledge to practical life: Why do we read the Bible? How do we read it every day without growing bored? How do we study a passage on our own? How do we pray with its words? And in the end we answer the embarrassing questions many are ashamed to ask.

You don't need to be a theologian or a history expert to read the Bible and benefit from it. The Bible was not written for an elite of specialists, but for ordinary people: shepherds and fishermen and farmers, mothers and young people. For two thousand years the Church has read it every day in her prayers, feeding her children, young and old, with it. All you need is an open heart and a little patience, and you will discover that this ancient book speaks about your life today.

How do you use this guide? Read one chapter at a time, preferably with the Bible itself open beside you so you can look up the references yourself. Don't rush; let each idea take its time. Before every reading, lift your heart in a short prayer, asking God to reveal to you the treasures of His Word. And now, let's begin the journey together.

And you are not alone on this journey — the whole Church walks with you. For two thousand years the Church has read this book every day in her liturgies and prayers, and the holy fathers explained it, lived by it, and wrote volumes filled with wisdom about it. When you read the Bible, you join a great

procession of believers across the ages: martyrs who died holding fast to it, monks who preserved it in their monasteries, mothers who taught it to their children, and young people who found in it answers to their questions. This great fellowship encourages you and upholds you, and reminds you that the Bible was not given to one individual, but to the whole people of God.

So don't be afraid of questions or difficulties, and don't think that faith means switching off your mind. The God who gave you your mind is the same God who gave you this book, and He delights in the honest seeking heart. Read, ask, pray, and search, and you will find that every honest question leads you to a deeper knowledge of God. This little guide is no substitute for the Bible itself; it is a small lamp to help you enter the great palace. Now then, let's start with the first and most important question: What is the Bible?

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Chapter 1

What Is the Bible?

We simply call it “the Book,” because it is the book above all books. But in truth it is not one book — it is an entire library of sixty-six books, written by about forty authors over many long centuries. The phrase “Holy Bible” means the book consecrated to God, set apart from all other books, because its source is not human wisdom but divine revelation. In it we find history and poetry, prophecy and letters and visions, all coming together to tell one great story: the story of God's love for man.

The Bible is God's Word in human words. God did not drop a ready-made book from heaven; He spoke through real people who lived in real times and places. Each writer wrote in his own language, style, and culture: the shepherd writes in a shepherd's language, the king in the language of kings, the simple fisherman in the language of fishermen. Yet the message is one, because the Holy Spirit led them all. That is why we find in the Bible both the warmth of human speech and the depth of divine truth — it is close to our hearts because it was written by human pens like ours, and it is great because it carries God's own mind.

The Bible is divided into two great parts, which we call the Old Testament and the New Testament. The Old Testament tells what happened before the coming of the Lord Christ: God's creation of the world, His choice of the people of Israel, His leading them through history, and His many promises of a coming Savior. The New Testament tells the fulfillment of those promises: the birth, life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ, and the birth of the Church and the spread of faith in the world. The two testaments complete each other like promise and fulfillment: the New cannot be truly understood without the Old, and the Old is not complete without the New.

Why do we trust this book and read it? Because it is not merely a historical record or a collection of beautiful sayings, but the living Word of God addressed to us today. The Bible says of itself: “All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for

instruction in righteousness” (2 Tim 3:16). It teaches us who God is, rebukes us when we go astray, corrects our path when we wander, and trains us in righteousness. It is not a book of information only, but a book for the whole of life.

The Bible was not written to be kept on shelves or to decorate homes, but to be read and lived. It is a personal letter from God to you: He wants to make Himself known to you, to guide you in your decisions, to comfort you in your sorrows, and to gladden you with His promises. Every time you open it you will find light for your next step, however small. That is why it was called a “lamp” that lights the way — so begin your journey with it in confidence, for the One who inspired it is able to speak through it to your heart today, just as He spoke to the hearts of millions across the ages.

In our Coptic Orthodox Church the Bible holds an honored place in worship itself. In every Liturgy a passage from the Epistles and a passage from the Gospel are read, and the people stand in reverence to listen; after the Gospel reading the Bible is kissed as a sign of love and honor for God's Word. In the prayers of the Agpeya we repeat the Psalms throughout the day, and on feasts the readings are chanted in the order wisely arranged in the Katameros. The Bible for us is not a book for academic study only, but a living part of our daily prayer — we read it standing in church and carry it in our hearts to our homes and our work.

Finally, remember that the Bible is at its core a love letter. God was not compelled to reveal Himself to us, but He did so because He loves us and wants us to know Him. As a lover writes letters to his beloved to draw near to him, so God wrote for us this long book to draw near to us. Every page bears the signature of His love: in creation we see His power, in the Law His holiness, in the prophets His zeal, and in the Gospels His face. So read it as love letters are read: with an open heart and a real longing to meet its Author.

Chapter 2

How Was the Bible Written?

Imagine about forty different writers joining together to produce one unified book! That is what happened with the Bible. The writers came from every class and profession: Moses, who was raised in Pharaoh's palace and learned the wisdom of the Egyptians; David the shepherd who became a king and a poet; Amos who gathered sycamore fruit; Matthew the tax collector; Peter and John the simple fishermen; Luke the educated physician; and Paul the scholar steeped in the Law. Completely different men in education, background, and personality — yet their writings came out in amazing harmony.

Nor did these writers live at one time; their writing stretched over about sixteen hundred years. Moses began writing some fifteen centuries before the birth of the Lord Christ, and the apostle John wrote the last books near the end of the first century AD. Sixteen centuries separate the first line from the last! Across those long centuries kingdoms changed, empires fell, and languages and cultures shifted — yet the message remained one and unchanged. That alone is a powerful testimony that behind all these writers stood one greater Author directing the whole work.

We call this divine work “inspiration.” Inspiration means that the Holy Spirit led the writers and guided them in what they wrote, so that their writings expressed God's mind precisely. But inspiration did not erase the writer's personality or style; it used them. That is why we notice clear differences between the books: Luke the physician writes in an orderly, precise style as if recording a medical report; John the Beloved writes in a language full of love and spiritual depth; Paul argues and proves like the careful scholar; and David sings and weeps and rejoices like the sensitive poet. The Holy Spirit is like the wind that fills different ships' sails, so they all sail to the same harbor though they differ in size and shape.

The Old Testament was written mostly in Hebrew, the language of the people of Israel, with a few passages in Aramaic, the everyday language of the exile period and after. The New Testament was written in Greek, because it was the

common world language in the apostles' time, spoken by people from Rome to Alexandria. The choice of these languages was no coincidence but divine arrangement: Hebrew preserved the promise for one people, and Greek carried the good news to the whole world.

Despite this enormous diversity of writers, times, languages, and styles, you find in the Bible one consistent message from the first book of Genesis to the last book of Revelation: God loves man; man fell into sin and was separated from God; and God arranged salvation through Jesus Christ. You will not find one writer contradicting another in the essence of the faith; they all complete one another like the members of one body. This amazing agreement across sixteen centuries cannot be explained except by one Spirit speaking in them all.

The Bible sums up this truth in a single verse: "For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost" (2 Pet 1:21). No one wrote of himself or by his own choice; the Holy Spirit carried them as a ship is carried by the wind. So when you read the Bible, you are not reading men's opinions about God — you are hearing God Himself speaking to you through the words of men He chose and guided. This is the confidence on which we build our daily reading.

And God has watched over His Word through the ages with marvelous care. The Jews copied the Old Testament books with astonishing precision, counting letters and words to make sure the copy was sound, and the early Christians copied the New Testament and spread it everywhere despite persecution. Today scholars possess thousands of ancient manuscripts testifying to the accuracy of the text in our hands. And when the Qumran manuscripts were discovered in the mid-twentieth century, the text of Isaiah in them was found to match almost exactly the text we read today, though more than two thousand years separate them! It is God's preserving hand that kept His Word to reach us intact.

Chapter 3

The Old Testament

The Old Testament is the first part of the Bible, telling of God's dealings with humanity and with His people Israel before the coming of the Lord Christ. It contains thirty-nine books, which can be divided into four main groups that are easy to remember: the five books of the Torah, the twelve historical books, the five poetic books, and the seventeen prophetic books. Each group has its own character and message, and together they paint a complete picture of mankind's preparation to receive the Savior. It is important to know that our Coptic Orthodox Church also reads the deuterocanonical books — such as Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, and the Maccabees — which reached us with the ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament and are read in the Church's prayers and the fathers' commentaries.

The first group is the five books of the Torah, the foundation of the whole Old Testament: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. In them we read of God's creation of the world and man, the fall of Adam and Eve, the story of the patriarchs Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph, then the people's exodus from slavery in Egypt by the mighty hand of Moses, the crossing of the Red Sea, the giving of the Law on Mount Sinai, and the forty years of wandering in the wilderness. The Torah lays the foundation for everything after it: who God is, who man is, what sin is, and how the holy God deals with His people. Moses the prophet wrote it under the guidance of the Holy Spirit.

The second group is the twelve historical books, stretching from Joshua to Esther. These books tell the story of the people of Israel in the Promised Land: their entry into the land under Joshua's leadership, the turbulent period of the Judges, the rise of the kingdom under Saul, then David, then Solomon, then the division of the kingdom into two, their successive falls into Assyrian and Babylonian captivity for turning away from God, and then the return from exile and the rebuilding of Jerusalem and the Temple. These books are not dry history but living lessons: when the people obeyed God they prospered, and when they turned from Him they fell — and God in all cases was faithful to His

promises and merciful to the repentant.

The third group is the five poetic books: Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs. Here the human heart speaks with God in the language of poetry and prayer. The book of Psalms is the Church's first prayer book: in it we find prayers of praise and thanksgiving, repentance and supplication for every circumstance of life, and we still pray it daily in the Agpeya. Proverbs offers practical wisdom for daily life in short, memorable sayings; Job wrestles with the deep question of human suffering; Ecclesiastes reflects on the emptiness of life without God; and the Song of Songs paints a poetic picture of love which the fathers interpreted as a symbol of Christ's love for the Church and the human soul.

The fourth group is the seventeen prophetic books, divided into the five Major Prophets — Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, and Daniel — and the twelve Minor Prophets, from Hosea to Malachi. They are called major and minor for the size of the book, not the importance of the prophet. The prophets were God's men who stood against kings and peoples, calling them to repentance, warning them of judgment, and proclaiming the coming of Christ the Savior. In their prophecies we find the most precise details about the Lord Christ hundreds of years before His coming: the place of His birth, His sufferings, His death, and His resurrection — so much so that Isaiah is nicknamed the fifth Gospel for the multitude of its prophecies about Christ.

When you read the Old Testament, don't read it as an ancient history book that has nothing to do with you, but as part of your own story. The God who created the world is your Creator; the God who led His people in the wilderness is the One leading you today; and the promises He gave to Abraham and David were fulfilled in Christ, in whom you believe. Read it searching for Christ in its pages — you will find Him in the prophecies and symbols, the sacrifices and the Temple — and you will discover that the Old Testament is not an introduction to be skipped, but the deep roots that still nourish our faith today.

Chapter 4

The New Testament

The New Testament is the second part of the Bible, containing twenty-seven books that tell of the fulfillment of God's promises in the person of Jesus Christ. They were all written in the first century AD, within about fifty years, by the apostles of Christ and their disciples. They can be divided into four groups: the four Gospels, the book of Acts, the Epistles, and the book of Revelation. Each group answers a question: the Gospels answer “Who is Jesus?”, Acts answers “How did the Church begin?”, the Epistles answer “How do we live the faith?”, and Revelation answers “Where is history headed?”

The four Gospels are the heart of the New Testament: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. Each Gospel presents a picture of the Lord Christ from an angle that completes the others without contradicting them, like four witnesses telling the same event. Matthew wrote for the Jews and presented Christ as the “King” promised in the prophecies. Mark wrote for the Romans and presented Christ as the strong, swift-acting “Servant” — which is why his Gospel is the shortest and fastest-paced. Luke the educated physician wrote for the Greeks and presented Christ as the “perfect Man” full of mercy, and he alone records many of the beloved parables. John wrote last to present the theological depth, affirming that Jesus is the “Son of God,” the incarnate Word. Together they give us the complete picture of who Christ is and what He did.

The book of Acts, also written by Luke the evangelist, is the story of the Church's birth and spread. It begins with the descent of the Holy Spirit on the disciples on the day of Pentecost, then traces how faith went out from Jerusalem to Judea and Samaria and to the ends of the earth. In it we meet great figures: Peter the bold preacher, Stephen the first martyr, Philip the evangelist, Barnabas the encourager, and Paul the apostle who carried the Gospel to the nations on his three missionary journeys. This book teaches us that the Church was born of the Holy Spirit and grows through preaching and witness — the living model for our Church to this day.

The Epistles are letters the apostles wrote to real churches and individuals facing real problems like ours. Most are from the hand of St. Paul the apostle — fourteen letters from Romans to Hebrews — dealing with faith and grace, salvation and practical Christian life. Then the letter of James on faith working through love, the two letters of Peter on standing firm in hardship, the three letters of John on love and truth, and the letter of Jude on contending for the faith. These letters make faith practical: how we deal with one another at home, at work, and in church, and how we face trials, divisions, and heresies.

The book of Revelation is the last book of the Bible, written by the apostle John while exiled on the island of Patmos. It is the New Testament's book of prophecy, full of visions and symbols picturing the conflict between the kingdom of God and the kingdom of evil throughout history. It was written to comfort persecuted Christians and assure them that the end is settled: Christ is the Victor, Satan is defeated, and a day is coming when every tear will be wiped away and God will make a new heaven and a new earth. So this book is read with hope, not fear — it closes the whole Bible with the promise of eternal joy and the Church's last prayer: Even so, come, Lord Jesus.

The whole New Testament revolves around one person, Jesus Christ: the Gospels tell His life, Acts tells the work of His Spirit in the Church, the Epistles explain His teachings, and Revelation proclaims His second coming and glory. Whoever reads the New Testament comes to know Christ up close: hearing His words, seeing His miracles, watching His love for sinners, and standing before His cross and resurrection. That is why we advise every beginner to start reading here, with the Gospels — for knowing Christ is the key to understanding the whole Bible, and it is also the beginning of true Christian life.

And from God's marvelous providence, the New Testament was written in Greek, the common world language of that age, spoken by the merchant in Rome, the philosopher in Athens, and the Jew in Alexandria. For Christ came in the “fullness of time,” when the Roman Empire had united the world with safe roads and one language, so the Gospel spread with a speed that would not have been possible before. God prepares the stage before He sends the actors: He prepared the language, the roads, and the peace — then sent His Son, then

sent His apostles with the written Word to establish the churches and enlighten the generations.

Chapter 5

How Was the Bible Compiled?

A natural question every serious reader asks: Who chose these particular books and gathered them into one volume? And why these books and not others? In the early centuries many writings circulated among Christians — so how did the Church know which were God's Word and which were not? The answer to this question increases our confidence in the book in our hands, for it reveals that its gathering was no accident and no hasty human decision, but a long work led by the Holy Spirit in the Church's life.

The important truth first: the Church did not “invent” the canon of Scripture or grant the books their authority; she “recognized” the books that already carried God's authority in themselves. These books had been read in worship since the days of the apostles, and believers distinguished the voice of the Good Shepherd in them as sheep distinguish their shepherd's voice. The Church's role was like that of a jeweler distinguishing real gold from counterfeit: he does not make the gold; he knows it and testifies to it. So the Church received the books generation after generation, and witnessed that they are God's Word.

When questionable writings appeared, the Church set clear standards for discernment, which can be summed up in four: first, apostolic origin — that the book was written by an apostle or a close disciple of the apostles. Second, agreement with the faith handed down from the apostles — no book contradicting what the Church received would be accepted. Third, wide spread and general acceptance — that the churches everywhere had used it in worship since early times. Fourth, spiritual fruit — for God's true Word changes hearts and builds up souls. By these standards the Church excluded the later spurious writings and held fast to the books she had received from the apostles.

As for the Old Testament, the Church received it from the Jewish synagogue, but in its Greek form known as the Septuagint translation. This translation was completed in Alexandria centuries before Christ's birth, and it was the Bible

used by the apostles and the early Christians — most of the New Testament's quotations from the Old Testament are taken from it. Through it we also received the deuterocanonical books which our Coptic Orthodox Church reads along with the other Eastern and Catholic Churches — beloved books rich in wisdom and piety, such as Wisdom and Sirach.

As for the New Testament, the four Gospels and Paul's letters were known and circulated in the churches from the end of the first century, and believers collected them and read them in their gatherings. With time, early lists of the accepted books appeared; then the Church councils of the fourth and fifth centuries, such as the councils of Hippo and Carthage, formally confirmed what the Church had been practicing for generations: that these twenty-seven books are God's Word. The decision was not the creation of a new authority, but the recognition of an authority already present and tested.

The practical takeaway of this chapter: you are not reading a book gathered by individuals according to their own opinions, but a book the Church has faithfully guarded for two thousand years, whose price was paid in the blood of martyrs who died holding fast to it. When you open the Bible, you hold the fruit of the Church's whole life: fathers who preserved it, copyists who transmitted it accurately, martyrs who died for it, and saints who lived by it. So read it with confidence and reverence, and read it in the spirit of the Church that handed it to you — for she is the faithful interpreter of it and the guardian of its true meaning across the ages.

And among the greatest testimonies to this book's holiness is the blood of the martyrs shed for it. In the ages of persecution, Roman governors ordered Christians to hand over their sacred books to be burned, and many preferred death to surrendering the book. Believers defended their copies of the Gospels and Epistles with their lives, because they knew they were not mere papers but God's precious Word. When you hold your copy of the Bible today, remember that the price of its reaching you was very great: the prayers and tears and blood of entire generations. Doesn't a book of such price deserve to be read every day with reverence and gratitude?

Jesus Christ: The Center of the Whole Bible

If you want to understand the whole Bible in one sentence, remember this truth: Jesus Christ is the center of the whole Bible and its one subject. The Old Testament proclaims Him and promises His coming; the New Testament announces that He has come and fulfills the promises. He is like the sun around which all the planets orbit: you may not see Him named explicitly on every page, but His light shines on every page. Whoever reads the Bible searching for Christ finds Him everywhere; whoever reads it ignoring Christ misses its greatest treasures.

In the Old Testament we find Christ in the plain prophecies that preceded His coming by hundreds of years. Isaiah prophesied that a virgin would conceive and bear a son (Isa 7:14); Micah prophesied that He would be born in Bethlehem (Mic 5:2); and Isaiah drew the moving picture of the suffering Servant who bears our sins and dies for us (Isa 53). David prophesied in the Psalms about the sufferings of the cross and Christ's resurrection in astonishing detail. These many precise prophecies, fulfilled literally in Jesus of Nazareth, are a powerful testimony that the whole Bible points to Him and moves toward Him like an arrow toward its target.

We also find Christ in the symbols and shadows that filled the Old Testament. The Passover lamb, slain to deliver the people from death, was a symbol of Christ, "the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world." The bronze serpent which Moses lifted up in the wilderness, so that everyone who looked at it was healed, was a symbol of Christ lifted up on the cross. And Jonah, who remained in the belly of the fish three days and came out alive, was a symbol of Christ's resurrection on the third day. People did not fully understand these symbols at the time, but they were pictured lessons by which God prepared His people to receive the Savior.

The Lord Christ Himself affirmed this truth more than once. He said to the Jews: "Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me" (John 5:39). The Scriptures they studied were not

an end in themselves, but witnesses to Him. And on the day of the resurrection, He walked with the two disappointed disciples of Emmaus, “and beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself” (Luke 24:27). Imagine that lesson: the risen Christ Himself explaining to His disciples how the whole Old Testament speaks of Him!

And in the New Testament we find Christ face to face: the Gospels tell His birth, life, teachings, miracles, death, and resurrection; Acts tells the spread of faith in His name; the Epistles explain the meaning of His salvation; and Revelation proclaims His second coming in glory. He is the beginning and the end, the Alpha and the Omega. No wonder the Church's whole worship centers on Him: we pray in His name, we partake of His body and blood, and we praise Him in every Liturgy. The Bible leads us to Him, and He leads us to the Father by the Holy Spirit.

The practical application: when you read any passage in the Bible, ask yourself: Where is Christ here? In the Old Testament look for the promise or the symbol or the prophecy. In the Psalms look for His prayer and His sufferings. In the Gospels contemplate His person and His words. In the Epistles discover His work in your life. In this way your reading will not be mere gathering of information, but a living personal encounter with Christ. For the Bible is not an end in itself; it is the road that brings us to the Person: to Jesus Christ, who said of Himself, “I am the way, the truth, and the life.”

But beware of letting Christ remain in your reading a mere subject of study or a great historical figure — He is far greater than that: He is a living person who wants to meet you today. When you read of His love for sinners, remember that He loves you too. When you read of His healing the sick, ask Him to heal the wounds of your heart. When you read His words, hear them as if addressed to you personally. The Bible is not a window through which we look at the past, but a door through which we enter the presence of the living Christ. Read expecting the encounter, pray expecting the answer, and you will discover that the Word leads you day by day into a deeper personal relationship with the Lord Jesus.

Why Read the Bible?

Someone may ask: Why should I tire myself reading an ancient book written thousands of years ago? Isn't it enough to go to church and hear the sermon? The answer is that the Bible is not an ordinary book to be read once and put on the shelf; it is daily food for the soul. As the body cannot live on one meal a week, so the soul does not grow on a Sunday sermon alone. Daily reading of the Bible is the daily bread that nourishes our spiritual life and keeps us strong in a world full of challenges.

The first benefit of reading is that we come to know God truly. You can hear a lot about a person, but you don't really know him until you hear him speak himself. The Bible is God speaking: He reveals to us His holiness and love, His justice and mercy and wisdom. In its pages we see God the great Creator, the Good Shepherd who is near, the tender Father waiting for His prodigal son's return. The more we read, the wider our knowledge of Him, the deeper our love for Him, and the stronger our trust in Him. And true knowledge of God is the foundation of every sound spiritual life.

The second benefit is that the Bible is a mirror in which we see ourselves as we truly are. God's Word reveals what is in the heart — thoughts and motives we may hide from people, even from ourselves. When we read of God's forgiving love we discover the hardness of our hearts; when we read of His holiness we discover our sins; when we read of His faithfulness we discover our grumbling. This exposure may be painful at first, but it is true healing, for a doctor does not treat a patient until he diagnoses the disease. That is why the Bible says God's Word is living and powerful, discerning the thoughts and intents of the heart — it works in us like a scalpel in the hand of a skillful surgeon.

The third benefit is that the Bible is a lamp lighting the way of our daily decisions. The psalmist says: “Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path” (Ps 119:105). In our daily lives we face dozens of decisions: at work, in marriage, in raising children, in relationships, in money. The Bible

doesn't give us a ready-made answer for every small situation, but it gives us the principles and the light by which we discern right from wrong. Whoever is filled with God's Word finds his conscience more sensitive, his judgment of things more enlightened, and his decisions more balanced. Many have experienced that one verse they read in the morning was the answer to their perplexity in the evening.

The fourth benefit is that the Bible is our weapon in trials and our comfort in distress. When Satan tempted the Lord Christ in the wilderness, He did not argue with him by philosophy; each time He answered: "It is written." So it is with us: the Word treasured in the heart is the sword with which we face thoughts of despair, lust, and fear. And in times of sorrow, sickness, and loss, we find in the Psalms and the divine promises a comfort the world cannot give. Whoever perseveres in reading builds within himself a spiritual storehouse to turn to in times of hardship, and finds the Word present — lighting his darkness, upholding his weakness, and kindling hope in him.

The fifth and last benefit is that the Bible grows us and changes us gradually. We may not feel the change day by day, just as we don't feel our bodies growing day by day — but with persistence we discover that our thoughts have changed, our character has improved, and our reactions have become gentler. God's Word is like water that slowly irrigates the earth so the plant grows, and like healthy food that builds the body over time. So don't despair if you don't feel quick fruit, and don't stop reading on the pretext that you don't fully understand; persevere steadily and trust that God works His Word in you even when you don't realize it — for it never returns to Him void.

And there is one more beautiful benefit: daily reading turns our relationship with God from duty into love. At first we may feel that reading is "imposed" on us, but with persistence we discover it is a beloved meeting we look forward to. As a lover longs for his beloved's letters, so the heart that has tasted the sweetness of the Word longs for its daily appointment with it. Many began reading out of obedience, then found they could not start their day without it. This is the great transformation: from "I must read" to "I want to read" — from a heavy duty to a beloved encounter.

Chapter 8

How to Read the Bible Every Day

The most important practical question is: Where do I begin? Our advice to every beginner: start with the New Testament, specifically with the Gospel of Mark. Why Mark? Because it is the shortest Gospel and the fastest-paced; you will read it in a few days and come out with a clear picture of the Lord Christ's life and works. After it, move to the Gospel of John to go deeper into Christ's person and love, then read the book of Acts to get to know the early Church. After that you can return to the Old Testament: begin with Genesis, then the Psalms and Proverbs. This order is not a binding law, but a tested path that helps you build a firm foundation without getting lost in difficult texts from the start.

The second question: How much do I read each day? The golden rule is: a little that is constant is better than a lot that is interrupted. Start with ten or fifteen minutes a day, or one chapter. Don't set yourself a huge goal that leaves you frustrated in the first week. Better to read one chapter with understanding and reflection than to read ten chapters quickly with nothing remaining. With time you will find your appetite growing and your time widening on its own. And remember that our Church offers you a ready treasure — the daily readings in the Katameros, where the Church has wisely arranged suitable readings for every day of the year, so you can follow them and read along with the whole Church.

The third question: How do I read? Here is a simple three-step method. First, pray before reading a short prayer like: “Open thou mine eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of thy law” (Ps 119:18). Second, read slowly and attentively, and stop at whatever catches your eye or moves your heart, and read it again. Third, ask yourself two questions: What is God saying to me in this text? And what will I do with it today? You can keep a small notebook in which you write three things each day: a verse that caught your attention, an idea you understood, and a short prayer or practical decision. With time this notebook will become a precious record of your journey with God.

The fourth question: When and where do I read? Choose a fixed time and as quiet a place as possible. Many prefer the early morning before the day's busyness, beginning their day with God's Word as they begin their body with breakfast. Others prefer the quiet evening. The time matters less than sticking to it. Turn off your phone or put it on silent, sit in a comfortable corner, and make these minutes a sacred appointment nothing crowds out. With time this appointment will become the dearest part of your day, and you will feel the great difference between a day begun with the Word and a day begun with busyness and noise.

The fifth question: What do I do when I come across a difficult text I don't understand? First, don't be troubled — this is normal and happens to everyone. Mark it and keep reading, for many texts become clear through other texts you read later. Second, you can consult a simple commentary or ask your father of confession or a servant. Third, remember that the first goal of daily reading is not solving every puzzle, but meeting God and being spiritually fed. Even if you come out of today's reading with one verse you understood and lived by, you have gained much. Persevere in reading with faith and patience, and you will discover that the Bible opens its treasures gradually to those who persist in knocking at its door.

And don't forget your family on this journey — the Bible is a book for the whole household. Set aside a short time for the family to gather around the Word: read a small passage together, let each one tell in simple words what he understood, then pray a short prayer together. Children learn more than we think: tell them the Bible stories in an engaging way, encourage them to memorize a verse each week, and reward them for it. A home where God's Word is read daily becomes a small church, and children raised on the sound of the Bible in their home carry it in their hearts all their lives. Start today, even with five family minutes, and you will see its fruit over the years.

Chapter 9

How to Study a Passage on Your Own

Reading the Bible is one thing; studying it is something deeper and more delightful. Study doesn't require academic degrees — just a simple method any believer can learn and practice. We offer you three easy-to-remember steps: Observe, Understand, Apply. These three steps are the key to every serious study of the Bible, from the simplest personal reading to the deepest theological research. Observe what the text says, then understand what it means, then apply what you will do with it. Let's take each step in detail, then apply them together to a practical example.

Step one: Observe. Before you ask about the meaning, look carefully at what the text actually says. Read the passage more than once, slowly, and ask yourself the simple journalist's questions: Who are the people mentioned? What happened? Where and when? What words are repeated? Notice the small details — they often carry the big meaning. Write your observations in your notebook without rushing to conclusions. Many errors in understanding the Bible come from jumping to application before careful observation, building on what we thought the text said rather than on what it actually says.

Step two: Understand. After observing what the text says, ask: What did these words mean to their first hearers? Every text was written in a particular historical and cultural context, and understanding that context illuminates the meaning. Ask: What was the occasion on which these words were spoken? What problem do they address? Then ask about the general principle: What is the timeless truth this text teaches for every time and place? You can consult a simple commentary or compare the text with other passages on the same subject, for Scripture interprets itself. Beware of loading the text with a meaning of your own that its author never intended.

Step three: Apply. This is the whole goal of study, for knowledge without application is like food that is seen but not eaten. Ask yourself: What does God want me to change in my life based on this text? Is there a commandment to obey? A sin to repent of? A promise to hold onto? An example to follow? Make

the application specific and practical: don't say "I will be better," say "I will do such-and-such today." Write it in your notebook and review it at the end of the day. Sincere application, however small, is what turns study into life.

Let's apply the three steps together to the parable of the Good Samaritan in the Gospel of Luke (Luke 10:30-37). First we observe: a man going down from Jerusalem to Jericho fell among thieves, who wounded him and left him half dead. A priest passed by, saw him, and went by on the other side; likewise a Levite. Then a traveling Samaritan came, and when he saw him he had compassion, drew near, bound up his wounds, pouring on oil and wine, set him on his own animal, brought him to an inn and took care of him; and the next day he gave the innkeeper two denarii, saying, "Take care of him; and whatever more you spend, I will repay you when I come back." We notice the details: the priest and the Levite were the religious ones, and the Samaritan was among those despised by the Jews — yet he is the one who showed mercy.

Second, we understand: the context is that a lawyer asked Christ, "Who is my neighbor?" — wanting to justify himself and define a narrow circle for his love. So Christ answered him with this parable to turn the question around: don't ask who your neighbor is; be a neighbor yourself to every needy person. The meaning is that a neighbor is not one who shares your religion or race, but one to whom you show mercy. And the touching irony is that the religious men passed by without helping, while the despised stranger is the one who had compassion, served, and spent of his money and time. The general principle: true love is measured by deeds, not words, and it crosses every barrier.

Third, we apply: ask yourself this week: Who is the "wounded man on my road"? Perhaps a sick neighbor who needs a visit, or a burdened coworker who needs a word of encouragement, or a poor person who needs help — or even someone who wronged you and whom you avoid. Choose one person and one specific act of mercy: a visit, a phone call, material help, or a prayer for him. Write it in your notebook and do it before the week's end. In this way, studying the parable turns from a beautiful story you heard into a life you lived. Try these three steps yourself on the parable of the Lost Sheep (Luke 15), and you will discover for yourself the joy of personal Bible study.

Praying with God's Word

Prayer and Bible reading are inseparable twins: reading is God speaking to us, and prayer is us speaking to God. But there is a beautiful secret that joins them: praying with the very words of the Bible. When you cannot express what is in your heart, you find in the Bible ready words, inspired by the Holy Spirit, that express you better than you express yourself. That is why the Psalms have been God's people's prayer book since ancient times, and our Church still prays them daily in the seven prayers of the Agpeya, as priest, deacon, and people all join in one prayer with God's Word.

How do you pray with the Psalms? Choose a psalm that fits your state: if you are joyful, pray with a psalm of praise; if you are sorrowful, pray with a psalm of supplication; if you have sinned, pray with a psalm of repentance, like the Fiftieth Psalm. Read the psalm slowly — not as one reading a lesson, but as one speaking with a beloved. Stop at every phrase that touches your heart and repeat it as if it were your own words: when the psalmist says, “The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want” (Ps 23:1), say it yourself with conviction: Lord, You are my shepherd; I shall not want. Turn reading into conversation: read a verse, then talk to God about it, then read the next. You will discover that a single psalm may take you a long time in prayer — and that is exactly the point.

The second face of praying with the Word is memorizing verses by heart. The psalmist says: “Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee” (Ps 119:11). A memorized verse is a treasure you carry with you wherever you go: on the road, at work, and in times of trial when the book is not in your hands. Start with short, easy verses like: “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life” (John 3:16), and “I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me” (Phil 4:13). Write the verse on a small card, put it in your pocket or on your mirror, and repeat it several times a day until you memorize it.

And memorization bears marvelous practical fruit: when you face a trial or an evil thought, you find the memorized verse rising to the surface of your mind like a drawn sword — just as Christ faced Satan with “It is written.” When something grieves you, you find the verse of comfort present, soothing your heart. And when you need to encourage someone else, you find the fitting word on your tongue. So encourage your children too to memorize verses from childhood, for what is planted in a young heart bears fruit all through life. Make memorization a fun family game: one verse a week that everyone memorizes and reviews together.

There is also a beautiful method called slow meditation: choose one short verse, read it over and over slowly, and each time pause at a different word and reflect on it. Take for example: “The LORD is my shepherd.” The first time, reflect on the word “LORD”: who is He? The Master of the whole universe. The second time, on the word “shepherd”: what does a shepherd do? He leads and protects and feeds. The third time, on the word “my”: He is my shepherd — mine personally! In this simple way, a single verse becomes a spiritual feast. Combine reading, prayer, memorization, and meditation, and you will find that God's Word is no longer a text you read, but a life you live and a breath you breathe every day.

And one of the most beautiful pictures of praying with the Word is what Paul and Silas did in the prison at Philippi: in the middle of the night, bound in chains and wounded from beating, they were praying and singing hymns to God, and the prisoners were listening to them. They had no open book, but the Word was treasured in their hearts and became praise in the darkest circumstances. That is what the Word treasured in the heart does: it turns prison into a temple, night into day, and sorrow into praise. When you memorize God's Word and pray with it, you are building within yourself a treasure no one can take from you: no prison, no sickness, no distress. Start today by memorizing one verse, and one day you will find it is the light that shines for you in your darkest nights.

Chapter 11

Questions Many People Ask

Why does the number of books in the Bible differ between churches? This is one of the most common questions. Protestants have sixty-six books, while our Coptic Orthodox Church and the Catholic Church also include the deuterocanonical books, such as Wisdom, Sirach, Tobit, and the Maccabees. The reason is historical: these books reached us within the Greek Septuagint translation which the apostles and the early Church used, so the Church received them, read them in her worship, and the fathers quoted from them. Protestants, on the other hand, limited themselves in the sixteenth century to the Hebrew books only. We respect everyone and love them, but we hold to what our Church received from the fathers, and we don't make this difference a cause of quarrel, but an opportunity for understanding and dialogue in love.

Another question: Are there contradictions in the Bible? Sometimes we read two accounts that seem to differ in details, and some become perplexed. Remember first that the four Gospels, for example, were written by different witnesses, and it is natural for each witness to mention details that complete the other without contradicting him — indeed, word-for-word agreement among witnesses would arouse suspicion more than anything. Second, some differences in numbers and names go back to copyists' errors across the centuries, which do not touch the essence of the faith. Third, our understanding is limited, and much of what seems contradictory today becomes clear with deeper study or wider reading. Read with humility and confidence together: confidence that God's Word is true, and humility that admits we are still learning.

Some ask: Isn't the Bible an old book unfit for our age? The answer is that there is a difference between culture and message. Culture changes: clothing, customs, and lifestyles in the Bible's time differ from ours. But the message is constant: God's nature does not change, man's nature in his need and weakness and sin does not change, and the way of salvation through Christ does not change. That is why you find a young man in the twenty-first century

reading a psalm David wrote three thousand years ago and feeling it describes his condition exactly! The Bible is old in its history, but new every morning to whoever reads it — because God's Spirit makes it alive for every generation.

And what do I do when I read a text I don't understand? First, don't fear or stumble — even St. Peter said that some of Paul's writings contain things hard to understand. Mark the text and continue your reading; light comes gradually. Second, ask: consult a simple commentary, or ask your father of confession or a servant you trust — the Church is a mother who teaches her children. Third, compare different Arabic translations, for sometimes one translation clarifies what was obscure in another. Fourth, pray and wait, for many texts opened up to their readers after years of prayer and experience. The important thing is not to let one obscure text deprive you of the Bible's many clear treasures.

The golden rule in dealing with all difficult questions is humility before the Word. We read the Bible to submit to it, not to judge it — to learn from it, not to pass verdicts on it. The questions themselves are not sin; God loves the honest seeking mind. But pride that thinks itself wiser than God's Word is the real danger. Approach the Bible as a student before his teacher, and you will find that most doubts melt away with knowledge, prayer, and spiritual experience. And if a question remains unanswered, place it in God's hands with confidence — for the One who gave us the book is able to teach it to us in His time.

A final practical question: Which Arabic translation should I read? The most famous and most widely used is the Van Dyck translation, published in 1865 — an accurate, faithful translation that remains the most used in our churches and meetings. There are also modern translations in simpler language that may help you understand, such as the Shared Arabic Translation and the Book of Life. Our advice: make Van Dyck your primary translation, since it is the language of the Church and the Liturgy, and use a modern translation when you need to clarify an obscure meaning. Avoid dubious translations issued by non-Orthodox groups that distort some texts. And if you master another language, read in it too — every faithful translation adds new light on the text.

Conclusion

We have reached the end of this little guide, but it is in truth the beginning of the journey, not its end. We have come to know the Bible together: what it is, how it was written, what it contains, how it reached us, who Christ is in its pages, and why and how we read it, study it, and pray with it. But all this knowledge remains theoretical unless it turns into a living daily encounter with God's Word. The Bible says of itself: "For the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword" (Heb 4:12). It is living because God's Spirit dwells in it, powerful because it works in hearts and changes lives, and sharper than the sword because it reaches the depths of the soul that no human word can reach.

Let me close with a simple invitation: start today, not tomorrow. Close this little book and open the big Book: the Gospel of Mark, chapter one. Read it in ten minutes, pray before and after it, and write in your notebook one verse that caught your attention. Then repeat it tomorrow and the day after. Don't despise small beginnings — the great river begins with a drop, and the great tree begins with a seed. And trust God's promise: "So shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it" (Isa 55:11). God's Word will never return void in your life.

I pray for you that you may find in the Bible what millions found before you: light in darkness, comfort in sorrow, strength in weakness, and joy in salvation. And that you may discover, day by day, that this ancient book is a personal love letter from God to you — by name. Start today, persevere steadily, and one day you will tell your children and grandchildren how God's Word changed your life. And grace be with you. Amen.

And now, before you close this guide, let us pray together a short prayer: Our Lord Jesus Christ, the incarnate Word of God, we thank You for giving us Your holy book as a light for our path. Open the eyes of our hearts to see wondrous things from Your law, open our ears to hear Your voice on every page, and grant us the grace to read every day with perseverance and to do faithfully what we read. Bless everyone who reads this guide, and make Your Word

living and powerful in his life, and a cause of blessing for his home and his church. To You be the glory, with Your good Father and the Holy Spirit, now and ever and unto the ages of ages. Amen.